

Part I — The Trap

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The curtain rises on an otherwise empty stage with a single short fountain basin in the middle. The two-level set of Act Two is gone — struck behind the dropped curtain in a fast scene change, not an interval; Act Three follows Act Two without a break. There is no garden, no backdrop, no trees, no painted cardboard. Only the basin: stone or concrete, with walls high enough that nobody can see inside it. The Boy-chair — the Boy — has been moved to the edge of the stage. The bundle is in the Step-Daughter's arms.

The Manager is plotting how to stage a tragedy on an empty stage with one prop. The Step-Daughter complains that this stripped set cannot hold the whole drama, because the Son spends most of the action shut in his room; how can an empty stage contain a man who refuses to come into it? The Father, suddenly philosophical, objects to the word *illusion*. He says the Characters have no other reality outside this one — that the Manager's reality, by contrast, may seem an illusion to him tomorrow. *Can you tell me who you are?*

This is the play's most philosophical stretch. The Father becomes, almost openly, the dramatist that Pirandello cannot help being. The Manager refuses the bait but is visibly unsettled. The Step-Daughter is impatient with the metaphysics — she wants the drama played, not theorised. Yet the Father's argument holds, because of how directly it is aimed: at the Manager, at the actors, at us. The audience is being asked, without warning, whether it exists in the same way the Characters do.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

*When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **Mother** is sitting on the right, the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair leaned against her knee. The **Son** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **Father** and the **Step-Daughter** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **Actors**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **Manager** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.*

Shrugging off the philosophical fog, he claims command he doesn't fully have — the breezy confidence is there to convince himself as much as the Characters.

THE MANAGER *[shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]*. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

She maps entry, resistance, and agency in one breath — against the Father's will, against the Son's, she came in anyway.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house *[Indicates **Father**.]* in spite of him... *[Indicates the **Son**.]*

Impatience as armour: he needs the Characters to stop owning the room and hand their pain back to a professional who can package it.

THE MANAGER *[out of patience]*. Leave it to me, I tell you!

She demands the record preserve her dissent, so no future accusation can claim she colluded in her own humiliation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

An involuntary shake, not speech — grief too old for argument, released as punctuation from a body that cannot stay silent.

THE MOTHER *[from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice]*. For all the good that's come of it...

Weaponising the Mother's suffering, she converts family ruin into a guilt-ledger she can keep billing the Father indefinitely.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her quickly]*. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

Triple repetition betrays the opposite of comprehension — he is placating, not absorbing, desperate to move the scene forward.

THE MANAGER *[impatiently]*. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

Raising the Child as both shield and witness, she aims her plea at posterity as much as the Manager — history must know she tried.

THE MOTHER *[the Child-bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it]*. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

She hijacks the Mother's testimony, redirects it as indictment, and savours the Son's cold distance as proof of the Father's lasting damage.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting indignantly and continuing for the **Mother**]*... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. *[To Manager.]* Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

Theatrical time against private tribunal — the second act is already losing to the wound the Characters cannot stop reopening.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

She claims dramaturgical authority: the story's geography is hers to dictate, not the Manager's to flatten into a convenient single set.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place at the fountain, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

A bare procedural prompt — he wants a practical answer but is about to receive an ontological one.

THE MANAGER. Why not?

She grounds the argument in the Son's isolation: shame lives indoors, not out in the open by the fountain the Manager would prefer.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he *[Indicates the Son again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

Retreating to production logistics, he uses the mechanics of stagecraft to avoid the emotional logic the Characters keep asserting.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

Nostalgia for fluid stagecraft doubles as a quiet dig at the Manager's rigidity — professional vanity dressed as historical fact.

PLAYER 1. They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

Condescension toward old audiences slides into condescension toward the child on stage — he cannot see the horror he is casually dismissing.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

Defending theatrical convention as audience service, she is unaware she is about to hand the Father his sharpest weapon.

PLAYER 2. It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

The word 'illusion' strikes like a slap — it is the precise term that would reduce his family's lived agony to mere craft.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]*. The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

Genuine bewilderment: he lives in a world where 'illusion' is neutral professional vocabulary, not a wound requiring an apology.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

Triple insistence on cruelty is itself a controlled display of injury — he is already philosophising the pain into a shape he can wield.

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

Trying to reclaim the word for professional use, he unwittingly demonstrates exactly why the Father cannot bear to hear it.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

Pride, not insight — the Leading Man wants his craft credited and stumbles straight into the Father's trap.

PLAYER 1. With our acting.

His tidy formula 'illusion of a reality' is meant to close the argument; instead it cracks the floor open.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

Soft recovery is the composure-tell — gentleness is the windup before a philosophical ambush neither the Manager nor the Actors can avoid.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer]*. I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

Professional indignation as self-protection: she cannot hear the accidental compliment buried inside the word 'game.'

PLAYER 2 *[interrupting indignantly]*. A game? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

He rehabilitates 'game' as art, then pivots to the trap: their art creates the illusion of reality, but the Characters have no reality outside illusion.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

His approving 'Precisely' is the last moment he holds the upper hand before the ground disappears.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

An unfinished sentence used as a rhetorical grenade — he dangles the implication and dares the Manager to follow it to its end.

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five Characters.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

Turning to his Actors for support, he converts collective bewilderment into a wall — defence by consensus against an argument none of them can answer.

THE MANAGER *[astonished, looking at his Actors, who are also amazed]*. And what does that mean?

Turning out toward the house and asking 'Who are you?' collapses the fourth wall; the trap is laid for the entire auditorium, not just the Manager.

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile]*. As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the Manager and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the Manager in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

His confident tautology 'I am myself' is the exact ground the Father is about to dissolve beneath him.

THE MANAGER *[perplexed, half smiling]*. What? Who am I? I am myself.

He halts mid-sentence — the pause is the argument; the Manager must feel the instability before it is given a name.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because you and I...

Laughter as first line of defence: the Actors mock what they cannot refute, and the Manager encourages it to re-establish hierarchy.

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! *[The Actors laugh.]*

Naming the trap openly, he watches the Actors' too-loud laughter confirm his point — performance and reality have already blurred past recovery.

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the Leading Man.]* to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. *[Quiet.]* You see — I've caught you in a trap. *[The Actors laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

Invoking procedural memory to escape a philosophical recursion he cannot win — 'we've had this before' as a procedural exit.

THE MANAGER [annoyed]. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

Dropping the philosophy, he presses directly: 'Who are you?' is no longer rhetorical — he genuinely needs the Manager to confront his own contingency.

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art [Looking at the *Leading Lady* as if anticipating her.] which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. [Beat.] *Who are you?*

Performing outrage for his company, he deflects inward crisis outward — social dominance substituted for argument.

THE MANAGER [astonished and irritated, turning to his *Actors*]. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

With quiet authority he distinguishes fixed character from fluid person — his most cogent moment, and his most self-serving: it justifies his own unchangeability.

THE FATHER [with dignity, but not offended]. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

Rank invoked as ontology — institutional title used as identity, the last card of a man losing a philosophical duel.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

He makes the trap personal and physical — not theory but vertigo: the self you trust today already buried an earlier self, so why trust this one to last?

THE FATHER. Only this: the man you are today once believed himself someone else entirely — someone who now means nothing to you, who barely seems to have existed. Don't you feel the ground go soft under you, knowing this you of today will look like an illusion to you tomorrow?

Spoken for the whole room: the frame has dissolved, and no one left on stage is certain where the play ends and something else begins.

PLAYER 2 [whispering]. Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

One factual sentence cuts through the Father's abstraction — his 'reality' was always territorial and predatory, and she was the territory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy]. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

*A silence. The **Father** does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.*

Admitting he has been carried somewhere he didn't choose to go, he lets 'where does all this take us?' stand as both question and concession.

THE MANAGER [rattled now, and covering it]. Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

Pressed for a destination, he says it plainly — they are only the 'illusion' he is accused of, and the Manager's solid self is no firmer; he merely believes it is.

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to this: we [Indicating the *Characters*.] have nothing but the illusion you call our reality. And you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

Irony attempted as exit — he suggests the Characters claim superiority — but it misfires because the Father will simply agree.

THE MANAGER [mocking him because the idea has unsettled him]. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

Two words of absolute, unironic conviction — certainty that admits no qualification is more unsettling than any argument could be.

THE FATHER [the greatest seriousness — no smile]. But of course. Without doubt.

Surgical interruption: she translates the Father's metaphysics back into money and flesh, planting the afternoon at Madame Pace's in the middle of the room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the same temperature; addressing the room, not him].* He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

Hollow surprise — he hears an odd interjection, not the accusation of violation that has just been dropped into the conversation.

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

Mild reproach assuming the Manager followed all along — he mistakes theatrical engagement for genuine comprehension.

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

Reducing the argument to a competition — who is more real — which is precisely the Father's point about the contingency of persons.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

He leaves the conditional hanging — the Manager's reality-changes are already conceded; completing the sentence would only soften the blow.

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

Defensive relativism meant to normalise flux, but inadvertently confessing to having no stable self — the Father's position all along.

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

Pre-empting the Father to drive the sharpest blade: their fixity is not a boast but proof of what was done and cannot be undone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[before the Father can answer — flat, precise].* His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

Forced to the wall by her, the philosophy turns to horror — their reality is fixed, nailed shut, condemned to replay the wound every night the play is staged.

THE FATHER *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has shown him].* No, sir. Not ours. That is the difference. Our reality cannot change — it is fixed, forever; it cannot be other than what it is. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* And that is what should make you shudder as you come near us: yours shifts with the day, and ours is nailed shut. We are the thing we did. And we will do it again tonight. And tomorrow. And every night you choose to put us on.